

Tragic Union

Marriage serves as a metaphor for the Sri Lankan ethos as well as the Tamils' fate

By Bunny Suraiya

This is as good a history of the conflict in Sri Lanka between the native Sinhalese and the transplanted-from-India Tamils as I've ever read. Yalini, daughter of Tamil refugees is born in the US, and through an exploration of the marriages in her extended family back in Sri Lanka, she traces the evolution of the tragedy that overtook the country after one cataclysmic day in July 1983, when the Sri Lankan government connived in the massacre of the minority Tamils by the Sinhalese majority.

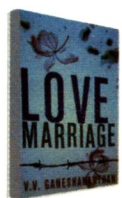
That was the day that marked the beginning of the Tamil separatist movement, which led to the formation of the LTTE—Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam, the Tamil word for "homeland", namely Jaffna, in the northern part of the island. That was also the day on which Yalini was born in far-off America; it was also the day on which her parents finally understood that they could never go home again.

The main strength of this book is that through the interweaving of human relationships it brings home, as no amount as political analyses can, the complexities of a conflict that has sent ripples across the globe. The author, speaking through the voice of Yalini, deftly uses the device of marriage to bring home to the reader a way of life that has been irretrievably lost in Sri Lanka, shattered by bombs, drowned in blood, ended by the random bullet.

There is Love Marriage, of course, which is the marriage between Yalini's parents. There is also Arranged Marriage, such as the one finalised between Yalini's cousin, Janani, who seeks asylum in Canada with her dying-of-cancer Tamil Tiger father, and who has a resentful contempt for her Americanised cousin, the narrator.

In between these two matrimonial pillars there is a host of sub-categories. In V.V. Ganeshananthan's words, these include: "The Self-Arranged Marriage, the Outside Marriage, the Cousin Marriage, the Village Marriage, the Marriage Abroad. There's the Marriage Without Consent. There's the Marriage Under Pressure. There is even Marrying the Enemy..."

All these are metaphors for love, deceit, betrayal, resignation, loyalty and flight—which define the Sri Lankan ethos and, more tragically, the Tamil condition within it.



LOVE MARRIAGE
by V.V. GANESHANANTHAN
Phoenix
Price: Rs 350
Pages: 320

TOP 10

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Aravind Adiga, HarperCollins
2. The 3 Mistakes of My Life
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa
3. Sea of Poppies
Amitav Ghosh, Penguin
4. One Night @ the Call Centre
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa
5. Five Point Someone: What Not to do at IIT
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa

NON-FICTION

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Rashmi Bansal, CII, IIM-Ahmedabad
2. The Secret
Rhonda Byrne, Atria
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Alice Schroeder, Bloomsbury
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